SEVEN YEARS WAR

THE SEVEN YEARS WAR of 1756 to 1763 has been described as the first true "world war" because it was contested on three continents. The British fought colonial campaigns against the French in North America, the West Indies, and India, while a major land war took place in Europe. Britain's Royal Navy began the conflict in some disarray and suffered an initial setback at the battle of Minorca on May 20, 1756. With Admiral George Anson installed as First Lord of the Admiralty in 1757, however, British naval fortunes soon revived. A close blockade of French ports executed by superb admirals such as Edward Hawke and George Boscawen inhibited France from defending its colonies. British naval victories at Lagos Bay and Quiberon Bay in 1759 scotched French plans for an invasion of Britain and put the Royal Navy in such a dominant position that it was in no way disturbed by the entry of Spain into the war alongside France in 1761. The peace that was reached in 1763 left Britain as clearly Europe's leading colonial and commercial power, with the French effectively driven out of North America and India.

SEVEN YEARS WAR

MINORCA



Date May 20, 1756
Forces British: 13 ships of the line; French: 12 ships of the line
Losses none

Location Off Minorca, Balearic Islands

Minorca, a British possession from 1708, had a splendid harbor that was considered a key asset for the British navy in the Mediterranean. In spring 1756 French troops landed on the island, quickly overrunning all but Fort St. Philip in Port Mahon. The landings were covered by a French squadron under the Marquis de la Galissonière. Admiral John Byng sailed from Gibraltar with orders to relieve the fort. His squadron of 11 ships was numerically comparable to that of la Galissonière, but many of his ships were in poor repair and undermanned.

The opposing squadrons sighted one another on May 19. The French admiral aimed only to prevent the British interfering with the land operations, and thus adopted a purely defensive stance. Byng sought to attack and on May 20, having gained the weather gage, came down upon the French line. The British approached at an angle, a tactic known as "lasking," designed to reduce the time during which the attacking line was exposed to enemy fire it could not return. But the approach went disastrously wrong. While the five ships of Byng's van engaged the enemy closely, the rest of his line fell behind, its progress hampered by a ship dismasted by French fire. Byng, on board *Ramillies*, lacked the flexibility to revise his plan on the spot. The French came close to surrounding the isolated ships in the British van, but mindful of his defensive responsibilities la Galissonière exploited the British confusion to withdraw from contact. Demoralized, with heavy casualties and half his ships badly damaged, Byng headed for Gibraltar to refit. Fort St. Philip fell to the French and the need for a scapegoat led to the court-martial and execution of the hapless Byng the following year. His death prompted Voltaire's famous remark; "In this country, it is wise to kill an admiral from time to time to encourage the others."



Execution of Admiral Byng
Admiral Byng is executed by firing squad aboard HMS *Monarch* in the Solent on March 14, 1757. He had been accused of "failing to do his utmost."



Embarking for Minorca
French ships embark for Minorca in May 1756. When they arrived, the French took all the British bases except for Fort St. Philip in Port Mahon.